

STUDI EGEO E VICINORIENTALI 1

ATH. NASTIA
LANTA

**STUDI IN ONORE
DI
ENRICA FIANDRA**

*Contributi di archeologia
egea e vicinorientale*

a cura di M. Perna

Napoli - 2005

DIFFUSION: DE BOCCARD
11, RUE DE MÉDICIS - 75006 - PARIS

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An Unpublished Inscription in Linear A from the Skoteino Cave, Crete (SKO Zc 1)*

Massimo Perna – Athanasia Kanta – Loeta Tyree

The cave of Skoteino in the District of Pedhiadha is one of the most important Minoan sacred caves. It has attracted attention since the days of Sir Arthur Evans and Paul Faure has noted the concretions, stalactites and stalagmites, with forms reminding of humans and animals¹. The cave was excavated for several days in 1962 by Professor Costis Davaras, after reports of looting. The excavation took place in several areas around these concretions and a lot of pottery was recovered as well as three Neopalatial bronze figurines of adorants². The Skoteino material is at present prepared for publication. The first results of this study show that the cave was occupied in the Neopalatial period and subsequently in LM III A and LM III B. It was abandoned after about 1200 B.C. and was occupied again in Roman times.

The cult in Neopalatial times included ritual meals as the presence of tripodic cooking pots of various sizes, some of them miniatures shows. It also involved drinking as many chalices, cups and conical cups suggest. The two inscribed sherds published in this article are of Neopalatial date and belong to a simple chalice, a ritual vessel with a somewhat tall stem. This is a very common shape in the Skoteino material. The date of the two fragments ranges typologically from LM IA to LM IB. A LM IB date would be quite plausible but in view of the character of the deposit a more firm date is not available.

* The study of the two fragments bearing a Linear A inscription (Sco 187 and 188) took place in september 2004 in the Stratigrafical Museum at Knossos. We would like to thank Dr. D. Evelyn for his kind assistance.

¹ Paul Faure, "Spéléologie et topographie crétoises", *BCH* 82, 1958, pp. 508 ff.

² Davaras, *ADelt.* 18, 1963, B2, p. 312. "Trois bronzes minoens de Skoteino", *BCH* 93, 1969, pp. 620-650.

The Minoan chalice is descended from Early Minoan chalices which, however, do not seem to have a ritual character. The chalices used in the Protopalatial period are found in shrines or are associated with cult and often have a lobed rim. In the Neopalatial period the chalice becomes popular in cult deposits and often its form and applied decoration have an exuberant character. The size of chalices varies from the miniature to the very large. The sanctuary of Symi Viannou has provided an enormous range and number of chalices which give a clear idea of this exceptional Minoan shape³.

Inscribed vases are rare and this is a most unusual example of an inscribed clay chalice. At Skoteino there are relatively few examples of the elaborate chalice. But simple chalices are very common. Such examples, in several variations, are often decorated with reeds, which offer a good typological dating of this material; the stratigraphy of the various trenches was mixed, as is often the case in cave deposits and our dating is based on typology. The decorated Skoteino chalice is relatively small, has oblique sides and a base narrower than the rim. Some have a taller foot and a few are perforated at the base, thus being transformed into rhytons.

The inscribed rim fragments (fig. 1, 2) clearly belong to a chalice whose lower half is not easily determinable. Some of the Skoteino simple chalices presented here give an idea of the various possibilities for the vase's lower half. Fig. 3 shows a typical simple chalice decorated with reeds. The same basic shape is shown by figures 5, 7, 8, and 9. They are decorated with floral motives with the exception of fig. 8 which has an atypical motif of black lines. Fig. 4 has a narrower, more elongated shape. Our inscribed chalice could have a form like any of these chalices, or alternatively a tall foot like that of the fragmentary chalice on fig. 6. In this particular sherd the foot is perforated turning the vase into a rhyton. When all the Skoteino chalices are studied and drawn, rim diameters may show a difference in the variants of this shape. If so, it may be easier to determine the form of the lower half of our vase.

A.K. – L.T.

³ A. Kanta, "Cult, Continuity and the Evidence of Pottery at the Sanctuary of Syme Viannou Crete", in *La Transizione dal Miceneo all'Alto Arcaismo. Dal Palazzo alla Città*, Roma C.N.R. 1991, pp. 479-505.

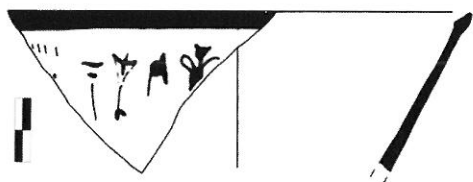


Fig. 1

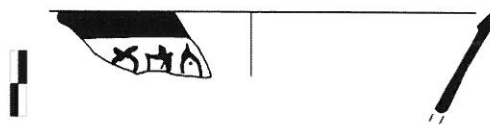


Fig. 2



Fig 3

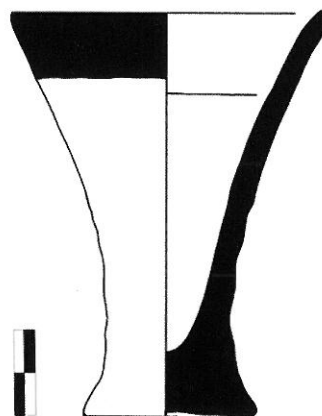


Fig 4

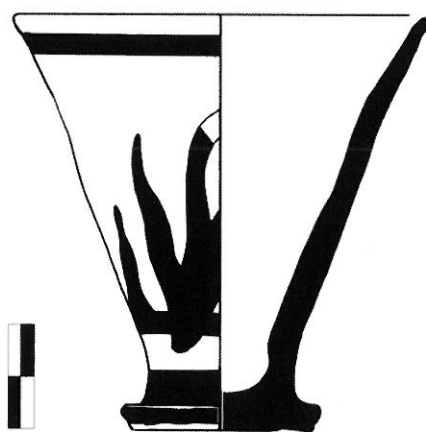


Fig 5

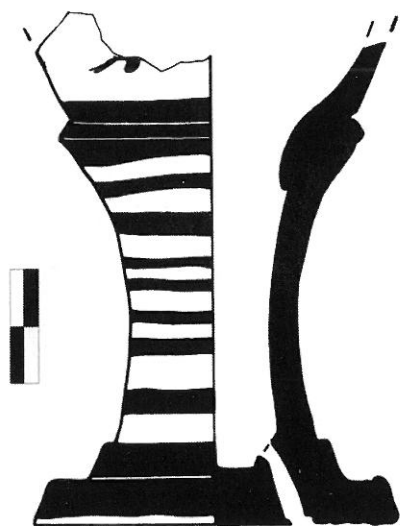


Fig 6



Fig 7



Fig 8

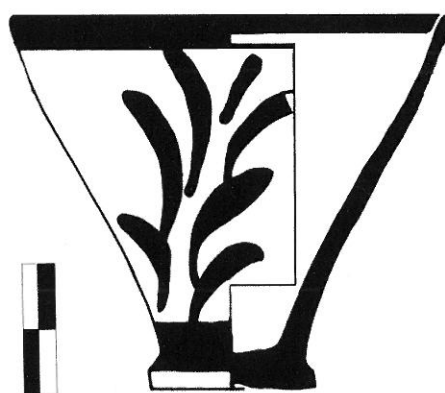


Fig 9

The Inscription

Two non-joining fragments of a clay chalice bearing a Linear A inscription came from the cave of Skoteino in Crete. The inscription is painted on the external surface of the vessel (Scot. 187 and 188; see fig. 10). The two fragments belong to the rim of the same chalice.

The clay is relatively pure and has an orange-buff. The painted signs on the two chalice fragments are eight in total, a punctuation sign probably included, and there appear traces of a ninth. In total at least two words are attested. Therefore, after the two long and famous painted inscriptions from Knossos (**KN Zc 6** and **7**), that unravel along the internal wall of the two clay cups, this represents the longest painted inscription, and only the fifth painted inscription in Linear A that has been discovered so far (fig. 11 a-b)⁴. Considering that, with the exception of the two Knossos inscriptions, the other two (**PK Zc 13** and **PE Zc 4**, see fig. 12 a-b)⁵ have only two to three signs, it is clear that the Skoteino inscription is particularly important.

*Fragment A (Skoteino Cave 187)*⁶

Fragment of rim. Dimensions: 8.2 x 5.3 cm., max. thickness 3.5 mm. (fig. 10). The fragment, (in dextroverse reading), shows traces of an unrecognizable sign, a probable punctuation mark and four signs painted accurately 1.5-2 cm. under the rim.

]vest. ., AB 06-AB 69 -A301 -AB 24[

Traces of a sign (?). Dimensions: [1] x [0.8] cm.

It consists of three small, parallel and vertical strokes and part of a fourth (the first from left) on the break. The upper half of the fourth stroke (the last from left) does not preserve any colour, but its trace is still visible on the

⁴ For the Knossos inscription **KN Zc 6** and **7** see A. Evans, *The Palace of Minos* I, pp. 586-588, fig 431a-b; and pp. 613-616, fig. 450-452. J. Raison, "Les coupes de Cnossos avec inscriptions en linéaire A", *Kadmos* 2, 1963, pp. 17-26.

⁵ For the Palaikastro inscription **PK Zc 13** see J. Boardman, "Unpublished Linear A Inscriptions in Oxford", *BICS* 5, 1958, pp. 11-12 and pls. III-IV; for the Petras inscription **PE Zc 4** see M. Tsipopoulou and E. Hallager, "Hieroglyphic and linear A Inscriptions from Petras, Siteia", *SMEA* 37, 1996, pp. 36-37.

⁶ The sequence of the two fragments A and B is arbitrary as well as the direction of reading of the inscription.

clay. Under the four vertical strokes, on the edge of the break, there is a large painted point.

Punctuation sign (?).

A small dot of colour is found between the traces of the previous sign, and the first sign that can be recognized in the inscription. It is difficult to establish if it is a punctuation sign or a fortuitous dot, as are often found on painted vessels.

Second sign. Dimensions: 2.0 x 0.8 cm.

Sign identifiable with certainty as AB 06 [NA]. The colour of the two horizontal strokes is perfectly preserved while that of the vertical stroke is slightly faded.

Third sign. Dimensions: 2.2 x 0.8 cm.

Sign of dubious interpretation. The upper half of this sign corresponds to the form of sign AB 69 [TU], a triangle with the apex pointed downwards, the base of which is crossed by an oblique stroke. But unlike the known variants of this sign, its lower half is not composed by a horizontal stroke, or slightly curved, but instead by an open arch facing downwards. The triangle's apex and this arch are united by a vertical stroke that is attested however in **ZA 4a.4** (fig. 13a).

The *ductus* of the sign is perfectly visible, only the two sides of the triangle are slightly faded or completely missing in places. The identification as AB 69 appears highly probable.

Fourth sign. Dimensions: 1.9 x 0.6 cm.

The fourth sign is compatible with A301, a very frequent sign in inscriptions on libation tables, where it appears in all the variants of the introductory word of the so-called “*formule principale*”⁷. It is found in many inscriptions of this type, but is poorly represented in economic archive documents. The sign is perfectly preserved, except for a miniscule scrap of colour that is missing.

Fifth sign. Dimensions: [1.9] x 1.2 cm.

⁷ See A. Karetsoy, L. Godart and J.-P. Olivier, “Inscriptions en linéaire A du sanctuaire de sommet du Mont Youktas”, *Kadmos* 24, 1985, p. 134.

The fifth sign can be identified with sign AB 24 [NE]. The lower part of the sign is missing and is on the break of the sherd. The colour is well preserved.

Fragment B (Skoteino Cave 188).

Fragment of rim. Dimensions: 4.3 x 2.0 cm., max. thickness 5 mm.

The fragment consists of three Linear A signs painted in a precise manner, at ca 1.7 cm from the rim of the vessel. Approximately the lower third of the signs is missing (fig. 10).

]AB 16-AB 67-AB 79[

First sign. Dimensions: [0.8] x 0.8 cm.

The first sign from the left appears as a semicircle from which two symmetrical and divergent curves stem. The colour of the left curve appears more faded.

The sign resembles AB 16 [QA], particularly in the variant attested on the bronze bowl from Kophinas (**KO (?) Zf 2**). Even in this attestation, in fact, two divergent traces depart from the circumference and substitute the two lateral 'ears' that are characteristic of this sign (fig.13b). A certain identification of this sign is not possible.

Second sign. Dimensions: [0.9] x 0.7 cm.

The second sign appears compatible with the AB 67 [KI]. As it occurs sometimes, the sign is rotated. The colour is perfectly preserved. Also in this case a certain identification of the sign is not possible.

Third sign. Dimensions: [1.0] x 0.6 cm.

The third sign is painted in a clear manner but its lower part is missing. The sign is compatible with AB 79, particularly in its variant that appears in the painted clay inscription **KN Zc 6.3** (fig. 11a). This sign presents a dot rather than a line within the oval and is lacking the 'rays' around the arch, characteristic of the majority of its attestations (eg. **HT 26b.3**, **ARKH 2.3**, **ZA 4a.5**, etc., fig. 13a).

All three signs can be compared to signs already attested in Linear A. However they appear in variants which are poorly attested. For this reason

we chose to dot the three signs, the epigraphical convention used to indicate dubious recognition of signs. It should be kept in mind that given the relative scarcity of painted inscriptions in Linear A, we possess a limited amount of material for palaeographic study and therefore we can hardly evaluate the differences of the *ductus* of **painted** signs with respect to those **incised** in clay, stone or metal; additionally, painted pottery inscriptions in Linear A, as well as in Linear B, do not seem to be the product of painters particularly experienced in the art of writing.

The type of inscription and its find-spot would confirm its cultic nature; for its technique, its support and the layout of its signs it constitutes a unique inscription.

Furthermore, contrary to many inscriptions on libation tables that often present the repetition of already known words, the Skoteino inscription furnishes two words not attested previously, which enrich the corpus of Linear A inscriptions and our knowledge of linear A palaeography.

M.P.

LIST OF FIGURES

Fig. 1-2. Drawing of Scot. 187 and Scot. 188. The fragments of the painted chalice.

Fig. 3. Scot. 82. Chalice decorated with reeds. Band around the rim inside.

Fig. 4. Scot. 83. Chalice decorated with a band around the rim.

Fig. 5. Scot. 84. Chalice with floral motif.

Fig. 6. Scot. 86. Foot of chalice-rhyton.

Fig. 7. Scot. 87. Chalice with floral motif outside and trickle decoration inside.

Fig. 8. Scot. 88. Chalice decorated with black lines outside. Band around the rim inside.

Fig. 9. Scot. 97. Chalice with floral decoration. Band around the rim inside.

Fig. 10a-b. Photo and drawing of the Linear A inscription **SKO Zc 1** on Scot. 187 and 188, scale 1:1 (M. Perna).

Fig. 11a. The inscription **KN Zc 6** (scale ca. 1:1), GORILA IV, p. 120.

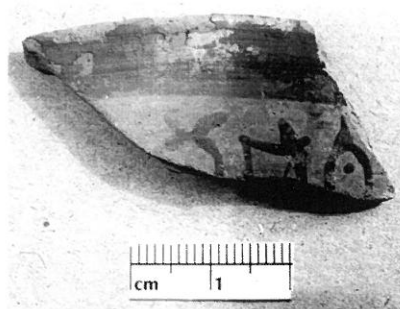
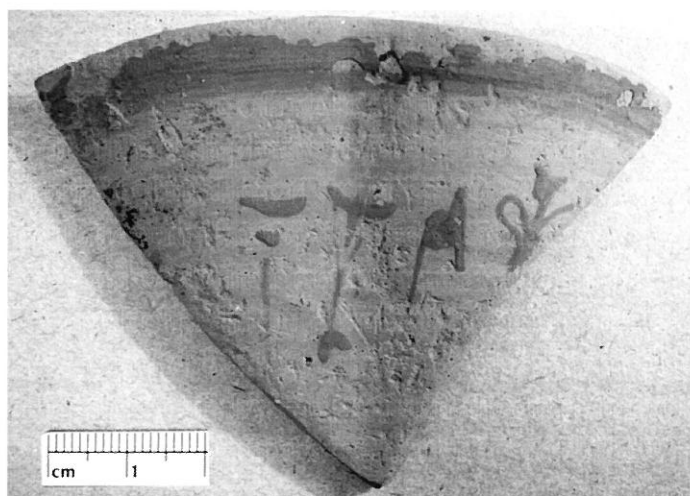
Fig. 11b. The inscription **KN Zc 7** (scale ca. 1:1), GORILA IV, p. 124.

Fig. 12a. The inscription **PK Zc 13** (scale ca. 1:1), GORILA IV, p. 127.

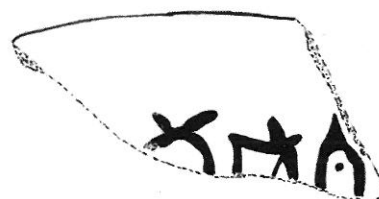
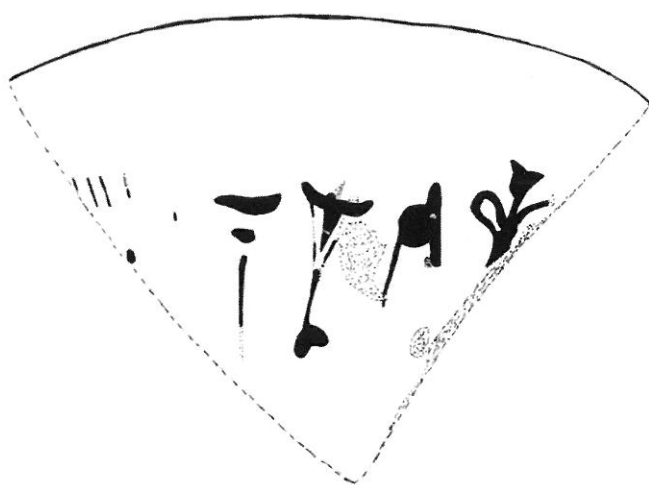
Fig. 12b. The inscription **PE Zc 4** (scale ca. 1:1), Tsipopoulou-Hallager 1996, p. 37.

Fig. 13a. The tablet **ZA 4a** (not in scale), GORILA III, p. 148.

Fig. 13b. The inscription **KO (?) Zf 2** (not in scale), GORILA IV, p. 158.

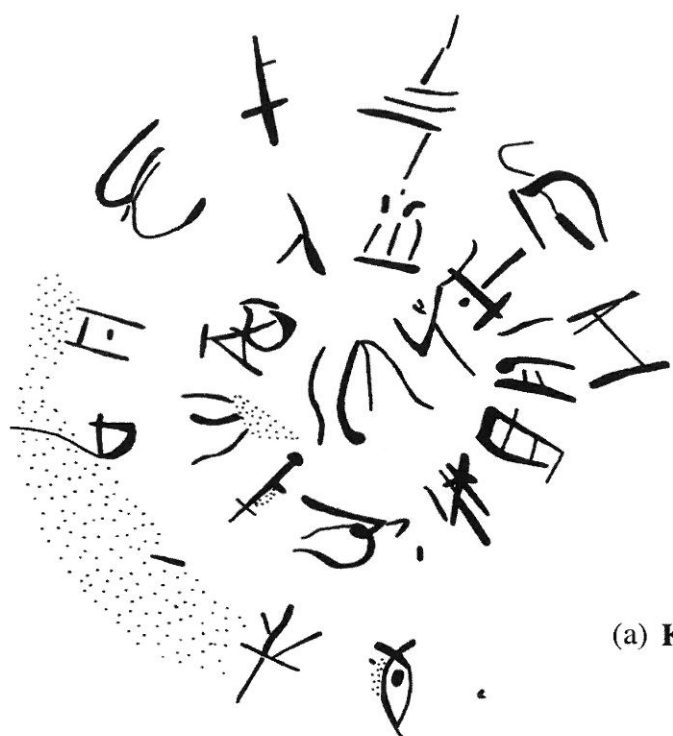


(a)

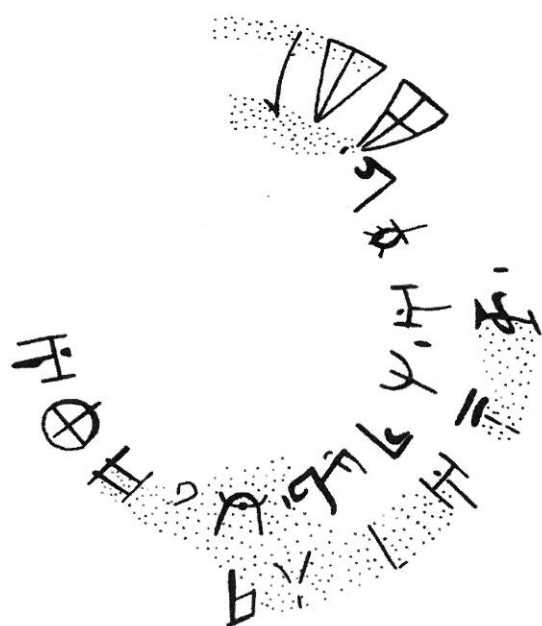


(b)

Fig. 10. **SKO Zc 1**

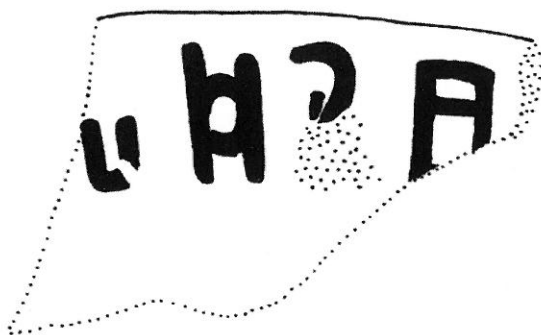


(a) KN Zc 6



(b) KN Zc 7

Fig. 11



(a) PK Zc 13



(b) PE Zc 4

Fig. 12



(a) ZA 4a



(b) KO (?) Zf 2

Fig. 13